Spot a scam: texts, calls and emails

Scammers change their stories, but they use the same few tricks. If you see any of these, stop.

The warning signs

A rush

"Act now", "your account will close today", "pay within the hour".

A code or PIN

Asking you to read out a code sent to your phone, or your PIN or password.

An odd way to pay

Gift cards, a bank transfer to a "safe account", or crypto.

A link to tap

"Track your parcel", "pay your fine", "update your details".

Too good to be true

A prize, a refund or an investment you weren't expecting.

Someone "official"

Says they're your bank, the police or HMRC and asks you to move money.

Your bank, the police and HMRC will never ask for your PIN or a code from a text, ask you to move money to a "safe account", or send someone to collect your card.

A message from "family" on a new number? "Hi Mum, I've dropped my phone, this is my new number." Ring them on the number you already have before you send anything.

Turn over: what to do with a scam call, text or email →

What to do

1 A phone call

☐ Done

1. Hang up. A real bank won't mind you checking
2. Ring your bank on **159**. It connects you safely to most UK banks
3. Or ring the number on the back of your bank card

2 A text message

☐ Done

1. Don't tap the link or reply, even to say "stop"
2. Forward the text to **7726**. It's free, and helps get the number blocked
3. Then delete it

3 An email

☐ Done

1. Don't open attachments or tap links. Forward it to **report@phishing.gov.uk**
2. Then delete it

4 If you've paid or given your details

☐ Done

Act quickly. Scams fool people of every age.

1. Ring your bank straight away on **159**
2. Report it to Report Fraud: **0300 123 2040** or reportfraud.police.uk
3. For advice: Citizens Advice Scams Action, **0808 250 5050**

Practise spotting scams, for free, with no risk

Scan the code, or go to **jamesgartshore.co.uk/go/scams**

Menu names can differ slightly between phone makes and updates. Free tips and drop-in help: jamesgartshore.co.uk